# ADDIS ABABA UNIVERSITY

## RESEARCH GUIDELINES: A COMPREHENSIVE REFERENCE

Prepared For: AAU Researchers and Graduate Students

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Focus: Thesis Writing, Proposals, Publications, and Research Ethics

# TABLE OF CONTENTS

Executive Introduction

Section 1: Introduction to AAU Research Guidelines

Section 2: Thesis and Dissertation Writing Standards

Section 3: Mandatory Research Proposal Protocols

Section 4: Citation Standards and Referencing (Placeholder)

Section 5: Ethical Considerations and IRB Approval (Placeholder)

Section 6: Data Collection and Management (Placeholder)

Section 7: Publication Rules and Policies (Placeholder)

Concluding Summary

Appendices and References

## EXECUTIVE INTRODUCTION

Addis Ababa University (AAU) is committed to maintaining the highest standards of academic integrity and research excellence. As the premier research institution in Ethiopia, the university requires a harmonious approach to scholarly output. These guidelines serve as a roadmap for navigating the complex requirements of graduate-level research, ensuring that every thesis, dissertation, and published article meets international quality benchmarks.

## SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION TO AAU RESEARCH GUIDELINES

This document consolidates research policies and standards from various colleges to serve as a comprehensive reference for graduate students and faculty. Its scope encompasses all Masters and PhD candidates, faculty-led research, and publications through the AAU Press.

### 1.3 Sources and Authority

- AAU Graduate Proposal and Thesis Writing Guides
- College of Health Sciences Institutional Review Board (CHS-IRB) policies
- AAU Data Repository, Sharing and Use Policy (July 2020)
- AAU Press Publishing Guidelines
- Ethiopian Research Ethics Guidelines (2021)

## SECTION 2: THESIS AND DISSERTATION WRITING

Universal success in academic research at AAU is contingent upon adherence to strict formatting and structural standards. This section outlines the required aesthetic and logical organization of the final research document.

### 2.2 Document Formatting Requirements

| Element | Requirement |
|---|---|
| Paper Size | A4 format |
| Font Family | Times New Roman |
| Font Size | 12 points (Body); 12 points UPPER CASE (Titles) |
| Line Spacing | 1.5 lines |
| Alignment | Left and right justified |

#### 2.2.1 Margin Specifications

| Margin | Measurement |
|---|---|
| Left | 3.0 cm (Binding) |
| Right | 2.5 cm |
| Top/Bottom | 2.5 cm |

## 2.3 Document Structure and Chapters

Each thesis is categorized into three primary divisions: Preliminaries, Main Text, and Reference/Appendices. Every major chapter must begin on a fresh page.

### 2.4.3 Focus: Research Methodology

The Methodology chapter is critical for ensuring validity. It must detail the research design, sampling techniques, data collection tools, and quality assurance measures taken during the investigation.

## SECTION 3: RESEARCH PROPOSAL WRITING

The submission of a formal research proposal is a mandatory prerequisite for all graduate students. The proposal acts as a contract between the student and the university, outlining the planned scientific inquiry.

### 3.2 Comprehensive Proposal Structure

1. Part I: Preliminary Sections (Title, TOC, Abstract)
2. Part II: Introduction (Background, Problem Statement, Objectives)
3. Part III: Literature Review (Theoretical and Empirical)
4. Part IV: Methodology (Design, Sampling, Analysis)
5. Part V: Logistics (Work Plan, Timeline, Budget)

## SECTION 4: CITATION STANDARDS AND REFERENCING

Academic integrity at Addis Ababa University (AAU) is fundamentally based on the accurate attribution of intellectual property. Whenever a researcher summarizes, quotes, paraphrases, or otherwise refers to work by another individual, they are strictly required to cite the source.

### 4.2 Accepted Citation Styles at AAU

| Style | Primary User Groups |
|---|---|
| APA 7th Edition | Social Sciences, Education, Psychology, Business |
| MLA 8th Edition | Humanities, Languages, Literature |
| Chicago Manual | History, Arts, Specialized Humanities |

### 4.5 ORCID and Digital Identification

AAU journals optionally require authors to register an account with Open Researcher and Contributor ID (ORCID). This unique digital identifier ensures accurate attribution and discoverability.

## SECTION 5: ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS AND IRB APPROVAL

The College of Health Sciences Institutional Review Board (CHS-IRB) is tasked with safeguarding the rights, safety, and well-being of all human participants involved in University research.

### 5.6 Informed Consent Requirements

- Information must be collected in an unlinked and anonymous fashion where possible.
- No personal identification may be recorded without explicit consent.
- Enrollment must be entirely voluntary after formal IRB approval.
- Physical and digital measures must be taken to ensure individual privacy.

### 5.7 Ethical Review Process Flow

Step 1: Proposal Development

Step 2: DREC Review

Step 3: College IRB Submission

Step 4: IRB Approval

Step 5: Data Collection

## SECTION 6: DATA COLLECTION AND MANAGEMENT

Established in July 2020, the AAU Data Repository, Sharing and Use Policy governs all research data generated by faculty and students through the Office of the Vice President for Research.

### 6.3 Data Eligibility Matrix

| Data Type | Description |
|---|---|
| Quantitative | Numerical data from experiments and surveys |
| Qualitative | Interviews, focus groups, and field observations |
| Biomedical | Clinical measurements and laboratory results |
| Geophysical | Seismological and astrological observations |
| Linguistic | Language documentation and corpora |

### 6.5 Researcher Responsibilities

University staff and graduates must ensure proper data generation, adhere to sharing restrictions, and comply with Ethiopian legislation regarding intellectual property and data protection.

# SECTION 7: PUBLICATION RULES AND POLICIES

## 7.1 Addis Ababa University Press (AAUP)

AAU Press is the only university press in Ethiopia and has served for nearly half a century as the university's primary venue for disseminating academic work to the wider public.

## 7.2 Publication Review Process

The publication process at AAU Press involves:

| Step | Description |
|---|---|
| 1. Submission | Manuscript presented to Board of Editors |
| 2. Preliminary Screening | Board evaluates initial suitability |
| 3. Peer Review | Sent to at least two qualified reviewers |
| 4. Board Approval | Based on reviewer recommendations |
| 5. Copyediting | In-house editing of approved manuscripts |
| 6. Production | Sent to printers for publication |

# 7.3 Review Criteria

Reviewers assess manuscripts based on criteria provided by the Press. The Board of Editors determines publication based on:

- Value and quality of the manuscript
- Recommendations of assessors (established scholars in their fields)
- Compliance with Press standards

# 7.4 Ethiopian Journals Online (EJoBS) Editorial Policies

## 7.4.1 Editorial Oversight Structure

| Board | Composition | Responsibilities |
|---|---|---|
| International Advisory Board | Seven acclaimed professors (international) | Ensure integrity, international standards, credibility through advice and comments |
| Editorial Board | Academics from AAU | Monitor publication workflow, ensure quality |

## 7.4.2 Editorial Responsibilities

The Editor-in-Chief ensures that:

- Referee teams evaluate manuscripts for scientific content free from racial, gender, sexual, religious, ethnic, or political bias
- No conflict of interest with regard to articles considered for publication
- Compliance with legal requirements regarding libel, copyright infringement, and plagiarism

### 7.4.3 Peer Review Process

Manuscripts undergo double-blind review where:

- Referees remain anonymous to authors
- Authors remain anonymous to referees
- Review process occurs before, during, and after evaluation

### 7.4.4 Timeline

Authors are informed whether the manuscript is accepted for publication within six months from the date of manuscript submission.

## 7.5 Author Responsibilities

### 7.5.1 Originality and Prior Publication

Authors must guarantee that their manuscript:

- Is their original work
- Has not been published before

- Is not under consideration for publication elsewhere
- Discloses any preprint posting (with link to preprint location)

### 7.5.2 Simultaneous Submission

Simultaneous submission of the same manuscript to another journal constitutes misconduct and results in removal of the manuscript from consideration.

### 7.5.3 Previous Submissions

If a manuscript has previously been submitted elsewhere, authors should provide information about the previous reviewing process and its outcome.

## 7.6 Authorship Criteria

Following the Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association (7th edition), to be listed as an author, one must have:

- Made substantial contributions to the conception or design of the work; OR acquisition, analysis, or interpretation of data for the work; AND
- Contributed to drafting the work or revising it critically for important scholarly content; AND
- Provided final approval of the version to be published; AND
- Agreed to be accountable for all aspects of the work; AND
- Agreed to be named on the author list and approved the full author list

Authorship Order: The degree of contribution shall be determined by the order in which names appear, unless indications are given by the authors to the contrary.

# 7.7 Prohibited Authorship Practices

| Practice | Definition |
|---|---|
| Ghost authorship | Contributors not listed despite significant contribution |
| Gift authorship | Listing individuals who did not contribute |
| Honorary authorship | Including names for prestige without contribution |

The addition or removal of authors during the editorial process requires justifiable explanation to the Editorial Board and publisher.

# 7.8 Plagiarism Policy

## 7.8.1 Definition of Plagiarism

Plagiarism is presenting another's ideas, words, or other creative expression as one's own. It may involve violation of copyright law and is punishable by legal action.

## 7.8.2 Forms of Plagiarism

- Word-for-word or almost word-for-word copying
- Paraphrasing portions of another author's work without clearly indicating the source

- Copying one's own previous work without mentioning the source (self-plagiarism)
- Copying equations, figures, or tables without proper citation and/or permission

### 7.8.3 Plagiarism Detection

All submissions are thoroughly checked for plagiarism using Turn-it-in.

### 7.8.4 Plagiarism Threshold

According to the Anti-Plagiarism Policy Framework of Addis Ababa University, the maximum allowed similarity is 30%. Manuscripts exceeding this limit will be rejected.

## 7.9 Conflict of Interest

### 7.9.1 Disclosure Requirement

Authors should disclose any financial or other forms of substantive conflict of interest that might have influenced the presented results or their interpretation.

### 7.9.2 Standard Statement

If there is no conflict of interest, the following standard statement should be added: "No competing interests were disclosed".

### 7.9.3 Examples of Competing Interests

- Individuals receiving funding, salary, or other payments from organizations that might benefit (or lose) financially from publication
- Holding stocks or shares from companies related to the research

- Holding or applying for related patents
- Official affiliations and memberships with interest groups
- Political, religious, or ideological competing interests

## 7.10 Acknowledgment of Sources

Authors must properly cite sources that have significantly influenced their work. Information obtained in private conversations, correspondence, or reviewing project applications must not be used without written consent of the information source.

## 7.11 Funding Information

If a paper results from a funded project, authors must specify funding sources according to their contracts with the funder.

## 7.12 Corrections and Retractions

When an author discovers a significant error or inaccuracy in their own published work, it is the author's obligation to promptly notify the Editor-in-Chief and cooperate to retract or correct the paper.

# SECTION 8: APPENDICES AND REFERENCES

## Appendix A: Key AAU Research Offices and Contacts

| Office | Responsibility |
|---|---|
| Vice President for Research and Technology Transfer | Overall research policy |
| College IRBs | Ethical review and approval |
| AAU Press | Publication of books and monographs |
| Institutional Repository | Data storage and sharing |
| Research Directorate | Research funding and support |

# Appendix B: Summary of Key Formatting Requirements

| Element | Specification |
|---|---|
| Font | Times New Roman, 12 pt |
| Line Spacing | 1.5 |
| Left Margin | 3.0 cm |
| Right Margin | 2.5 cm |
| Top Margin | 2.5 cm |
| Bottom Margin | 2.5 cm |
| Page Numbers | Bottom center |
| Plagiarism Limit | ≤30% similarity |

# Appendix C: Ethical Review Checklist

- Proposal developed with supervisor guidance
- Submitted to Departmental Research Ethics Committee
- IRB initial submission completed

- IRB approval obtained (documented)
- Informed consent forms prepared and approved
- Data collection tools approved
- Annual renewals submitted as required
- Final report submitted to IRB

# Appendix D: Publication Submission Checklist

- Manuscript original and not submitted elsewhere
- All authors meet authorship criteria
- ORCID IDs provided (if applicable)
- Conflict of interest statement included
- Funding sources acknowledged
- All sources properly cited
- Permission obtained for third-party materials
- Plagiarism check completed
- Format complies with journal guidelines

# REFERENCES


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